The Dhāraṇī of the Noble Eleven-Faced Avalokiteśvara

Āryāvalokiteśvaraikādaśamukhanāmadhāraṇī · Toh 899 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་སྤྱན་རས་གཟིགས་དབང་ཕྱུག་ཞལ་བཅུ་གཅིག་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་གཟུངས།

The Dhāraṇī of the Noble Eleven-Faced Avalokiteśvara, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Avalokiteśvara Ekādaśamukha Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan by a title beginning Phakpa Chenrezik, is a short scripture centered on the powerful heart mantra of Avalokiteśvara in his eleven-faced form. In it, the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara comes before the Buddha, accompanied by many holders of mantras, and explains that this mantra has been taught by countless buddhas of the past. He offers to reveal it for the benefit of all beings, so that it may pacify illness, avert evil, misfortune, bad dreams, and untimely death, and lead beings toward the path of awakening. This text is Toh 899 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the collection of dhāraṇī texts, the incantations and protective formulas preserved for recitation and practice.

In the language of India: ārya avalokiteśvara ekadaśa mukha nāma dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Dhāraṇī of the Noble Eleven-Faced Avalokiteśvara.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Avalokiteśvara, surrounded by many holders of vidyā-mantras, went to where the Blessed One was. He bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, circled him three times, and sat down to one side. Then he said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, this heart mantra called the Eleven-Faced has been spoken by one hundred and ten million buddhas. I shall explain it in order to benefit all sentient beings, to completely pacify all illness, to avert all evil, all inauspiciousness and all bad dreams, to avert all untimely death, to bring those who have not entered the teaching to faith, and to completely pacify obstructors and vināyakas.

"Blessed One, by this heart mantra protection is accomplished, full safeguarding, and full support; peace and well-being come about; punishment is averted, weapons are averted, and poison is neutralized. There is no one at all who can go against it. In the world with its gods, its māras and its Brahmās, with its śramaṇas and brahmins, I have not seen such a one, except for the ripening of former karma.

"This heart mantra is praised and held in mind by all the buddhas, the blessed ones. Blessed One, this heart mantra of mine is rejoiced in by all the tathāgatas.

"Blessed One, I remember that as many eons ago as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, there appeared a tathāgata called Light-Ray King Who Vanquishes the Age of Passion with the Crown of a Hundred Lotus Eyes. I was then a sage, and I received this from that tathāgata. As soon as I heard it, all the tathāgatas of the ten directions became manifest before me, and I also attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. That is why I cherish this heart mantra.

"Therefore a son or daughter of noble family who is endowed with faith should recite this heart mantra with reverence. Without attending to anything else, one should recite it constantly. If one rises in the morning and recites it one hundred and eight times, in this very life one will gain ten qualities. What are the ten? One will be free from illness. One will be embraced by all the tathāgatas. One will obtain wealth, grain and riches without needing to strive for them. All enemies will be overpowered and subdued. Assemblies of kings will be inclined to speak fairly. The body will not be harmed by poison, will not be harmed by venom, and will not be harmed by epidemic fever. One will not be harmed by weapons. One will not die by water. One will not die by fire. And one will not die an untimely death.

"Furthermore, one will gain four qualities. At the time of death one will see the tathāgatas. One will not be born in the lower realms. One will not die without having been freed from terror. And having passed from this world, one will be born in the world-realm Sukhāvatī.

"Blessed One, I remember that even further back than as many eons ago as there are grains of sand in ten Ganges rivers, there appeared a tathāgata called Fragrance of Mandārava. I was then a householder, and by taking up this mantra I cut short forty thousand eons of saṃsāra. By reciting this heart mantra I attained the bodhisattva liberation called the Heart of Wisdom through Which the Compassion of All the Victors Enters.

"For all sentient beings who are bound by bonds, those who are about to be bound, and those who are tormented by water, by fire and by suffering of every kind, I shall, through this heart mantra of mine, be a resting place, a protection, a refuge and an ally. Yakṣas and hostile rākṣasas too I shall summon with this heart mantra, turn their minds to loving-kindness and compassion, and establish them in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Blessed One, such is the great miraculous power of this heart mantra of mine. By reciting it just once, even the four root downfalls are purified, and even the five acts of immediate retribution are purified without remainder; what need is there to speak of practicing it diligently as taught? Such people will be ones who have generated roots of virtue under many hundreds of thousands of trillions of buddhas; what need is there to speak of reciting it and accomplishing its practice? I shall fulfill all their wishes just as they desire.

"Whoever observes a fast for my sake on the fourteenth or the fifteenth day of the month will cut short forty thousand eons of saṃsāra.

"Blessed One, to hold my name is of great benefit; it is greater than holding the names of a hundred thousand ten-millions of buddhas. All sentient beings who hold my name will abide in irreversibility. They will be completely freed from all illness. They will be completely freed from all obscurations and from all misconduct of body, speech and mind. Whoever applies it according to the rite will hold the awakening of a buddha in the palm of their hand."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, excellent, excellent, that you have such great compassion for all sentient beings! Son of noble family, through this means you are able to establish all sentient beings in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. I too uphold this heart mantra and rejoice in it, so, son of noble family, speak it!"

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, and spoke this heart mantra:

namo ratnatrayāya nama āryajñānasāgaravairocanavyūharājāya tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya namaḥ sarvatathāgatebhyaḥ arhatebhyaḥ samyaksaṃbuddhebhyaḥ nama āryāpalokiteśvarāya bodhisatvāya mahāsatvāya mahākāruṇikāya tadyathā oṃ dhara dhara dhiri dhiri dhuru dhuru iṭṭe vaṭṭe cale cale pracale pracale kusume kusumavare ili mili citijvalamapanaya svāhā

As for its rite, it performs all activities without any need for prior practice. For fever that comes every day, every second day, every third day, or every fourth day; for bhūtas, ḍākinīs, ghosts, kaṭapūtanas, and apasmāras; for goiter, strings of boils, skin eruptions and the like; for poison, blisters, itching and the like, one recites the mantra over clay and smears it on.

If one recites it seven times, it purifies the obscurations of karma.

For a child seized by a graha, use sesame oil. For an aching ear, use costus and sesame oil. For an aching nose, if one applies ground wheat, that will relieve it. It should also be applied to every painful ailment, and through recitation it succeeds.

This completes the dhāraṇī called Noble Eleven-Faced Avalokiteśvara.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Śīlendrabodhi and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

Translator's Notes

• The first tathāgata's name could not be confidently matched to a Sanskrit form, so it is translated by meaning: "Light-Ray King Who Vanquishes the Age of Passion with the Crown of a Hundred Lotus Eyes."

Here □□□□ is taken in its protective-formula sense of "punishment" (daṇḍa), not the philosophical sense "annihilation."

The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "die without having been freed from terror." The exact sense is uncertain. It may mean dying in a perilous or uneasy state (compare Sanskrit viṣama-kālakriyā).
• The term rendered "skin eruptions" is uncertain in the Tibetan; it evidently names a skin affliction listed alongside goiter and boils. The "ground wheat" for nasal pain reads the verb as "ground," so the remedy is wheat flour; another reading would be "applied wheat." "Without any need for prior practice" means the mantra works without a preliminary period of recitation to gain mastery of it.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.